

Dawn Paddle - Tidal Channel Notes

Personal | Clear Lake Shores channels | Kayak, three or four mornings a week

Notes on the channels paddled at dawn around Clear Lake Shores. Mostly for the quiet, partly to keep a feel for the water that the farm depends on. Tide rules everything; these notes assume you read the day's tide before you launch.

The regular loops

Route	Distance	Best tide	Notes
Cottage dock to back lake	2.1 mi	high, slack	skinny at low; mud
Channel run to the point	3.4 mi	incoming	watch boat wake
Marsh drains loop	2.8 mi	mid, falling	birds at dawn
Long paddle to the flats	5.2 mi	high out, high back	time the turn

Reading the water

- Launch on the last of the incoming if you want an easy paddle back on slack.
- The marsh drains go dry an hour either side of low; do not get caught up a drain.
- Wind against tide stacks a short steep chop in the open channel; hug the lee bank.
- Cold water is the real danger here, not heat. Dress for the water, not the air.

In the boat

Paddle, spare, whistle, headlamp before light, phone in a dry bag, water. Tell someone the loop and the time back. The dawn hour is the whole point; most mornings it is just the heron, the mullet jumping, and the sound of the paddle. That is the medicine.

Personal notes. Tide and cold water are the two things that hurt people out here. Respect both.